

- Q7. (a) The technological system is both primary and basic in importance as all human life and culture rest and depend upon it. Elaborate the statement in keeping in mind Leslie White's theory of cultural evolution. (15 marks)

Leslie White is an American anthropologist belonging to the neo evolutionary school of thought.

According to Steward, White is a universal evolutionist who gives an overall law of cultural development. In book "Evolution of Culture"

Culture advances as the amount of energy harnessed per capita increases or as the efficiency to put that energy to work is increased i.e. technology.

$$\begin{matrix} E & \times & T & = & C \\ \text{(energy)} & & \text{(technology)} & & \text{(culture)} \end{matrix}$$

Thus according to White culture is an energy harnessing system. Further he says this culture as a system has three components technological, ideological & structural

which mutually influence each other but technology takes the centre stage to influence structure & ideology.

White also gives a overall stage of development of human history where in

each stage the energy harnessing mechanism too has evolved.

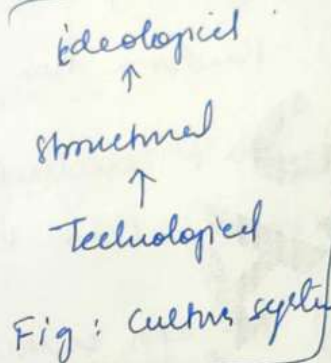


Fig: Culture system

energy evolution → Use of nuclear energy & fusion reactions

↑
Civilisation → Industrialisation & steam engines appeared thus use of coal & petroleum & steam etc

↑
Barbarism → New forms of energy trapped
ex: human energy + animal energy
Ex: Agriculture, pastoralism

↑
Savagery → Use free floating ^{human} Energy
Ex: Stone tools, human made

Criticism:

- ① Can't explain why certain cultures go extinct
- ② Pandora box of progress opened
- ③ Can't evaluate cultures where energy conservation is a goal
- ④ All agricultural societies (technology) do not have the same social organisation

Relevance:

- 1) Discuss on energy & technology is relevant in the 21st century which is focusing on sustainable living, resource management etc
- 2) How technologies like (AI, Bitcoin) shape the society is to be examined

Despite any criticism, White's contribution towards bringing back concepts of evolution in anthropological discourse is laudable.